GLASSHOUSE



Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

EXIT STAGE RIGHT

Rahul Gandhi's Bharat Jodo Nyay Yatra (BJNY) seems to have triggered a flurry of exits from the Congress party, particularly of second-generation leaders. On January 14, the day the BJNY began from Imphal, Milind Deora, a former close aide, switched to the Shiv Sena (Eknath Shinde faction). After the yatra left Assam on January 25, instead of a groundswell of support, two women leaders—Bismita Gogoi, general secretary of the All India Mahila Congress in Assam and Angkita Dutta, ex-state Youth Congress chief—joined the BJP. Gogoi is the daughter-in-law of former assembly speaker Jibakanta Gogoi and Dutta is the daughter of ex-Assam Congress president Anjan Dutta. Buzz is that current Assam Congress president Rana Goswami is also likely to jump ship. And to think Rahul had handpicked Goswami as an AICC secretary in 2014.



Ready for a 'Fight'

The Bharuch Lok Sabha seat in Gujarat could witness an interesting battle. **Faisal Patel**, the son of the late Congress leader and Sonia Gandhi's political advisor, Ahmed Patel, has thrown his hat in the ring with posters saying 'I will fight' appearing in the district in the past few weeks. His sister Mumtaz is also said to be keen to contest the seat where their father's legacy still holds good. All this is happening in the backdrop of seat-sharing talks with the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP). In early January, the latter had announced their candidate for Bharuch, firebrand tribal MLA Chaitar Vasava.

SLOW OFF THE BLOCKS

The Indian Political Action Committee (IPAC), the campaign advisor to Chief Minister **Mamata Banerjee's** Trinamool Congress (TMC) in West Bengal, is getting jittery. The Lok Sabha election is just months away, but the TMC is yet to crank up the poll machinery. Sources in IPAC, a brainchild of poll strategist Prashant Kishor, say they were supposed to deploy a person each in the 294 assembly constituencies right after Durga Puja, which was in October. Three months later, not one person has been stationed. "There is something off in the party...if the results aren't good, I fear we'll be blamed," an IPAC executive was heard saying.



ANI

Waiting in the Wings



Rajasthan chief minister **Bhajan Lal Sharma** is still living out of a suitcase, as he waits for his predecessor Ashok Gehlot to vacate the official residence at Civil Lines in Jaipur. Gehlot's shift is delayed because the house he has been allotted (previously occupied by former speaker C.P. Joshi) is under renovation. New Speaker Vasudev Devnani's house is not ready either. Another ex-CM, Vasundhara Raje, and ex-deputy CM Sachin Pilot should be happy on this count—no one has asked them to vacate their official quarters.

Battery Drained

Jayadev Galla, the Telugu Desam Party's leader in the Lok Sabha, is fed up. The general election is just months away, but Galla has declared he is quitting politics, apparently because he cannot speak out against the Centre (political limitations) or the state government (business constraints). The two-term MP and CMD of the Amara Raja Group, the country's largest battery-maker, is among the wealthiest MPs. He is also moving expansion plans to Telangana after being badgered over flouting pollution norms by Jagan Reddy's YSR Congress government in home state Andhra Pradesh.



Kaushik Deka with Amarnath K. Menon, Arkamoy Datta Majumdar, Jumana Shah and Rohit Parihar